

nation's needs. Germany brought all its railways together under the Deutsche Reichsbahn or the national railway, in 1920. In Britain, the government merged all the private rail companies into the "Big Four", which included the GWR, London. Midland and Scottish Railway (LMS), London and North Eastern Railway (LNER), and the Southern Railway (SR). In 1938, France brought all its railways together under the state-owned Société Nationale des Chemins de fer Français (SNCF).

## **Steam and speed**

As cars and aeroplanes shortened time and distance, the competition increased, the railways dived into the age of speed with the emergence of futuristic trains. Speed and comfort became the catchwords. In 1931, Germany's petrol-powered Schienenzeppelin set the speed record of 230 km/h. Steam wasn't far behind as Sir Nigel Gresley's Flying Scotsman, set a record of 161 km/h in 1934. Gresley, one of Britain's most famous steam locomotive engineers went on to build the streamlined Mallard in 1938, which clocked 203 km/h, a steam speed record that has officially never been beaten. Known as the Golden Age for steam, the 1930s also saw lightweight diesel trains making their presence felt in North America and Europe. However, soon, the shadow of war loomed over the world once again.

## **And the world goes to war again**

The railways had an integral role during the course of World War II (1939–45) for the Allied and Axis forces. Cheaply constructed yet powerful freight locomotives were used extensively. The German wartime locomotive Class 52 Kriegslok was an epitome of the machines built for war, and proved so reliable and durable that it played an important part in post-war reconstruction as well. The trains transported troops, military equipment, ammunition, and food. In Germany, they took on a more horrific role, transporting millions of people to concentration camps. The end of the war brought with it a time for rebuilding as the austere, powerful locomotives built for battle were now used to help with reconstruction.